

Participant Guide

School Leadership

This guide is yours. It holds a short summary of each session and every activity you will work on across the day.

Name (optional)

School

Welcome

Across today you will build a broad, mixed picture of Autistic experience, then turn it into one practical change in your school and one purposeful conversation with a family or student.

How to use this guide

- Each session opens with a one-page summary of the key ideas.
- Activity pages follow, ready to write on. Some are done alone, some with a partner, a trio or a small group.
- Keep two or three real students in mind all day. Choose students who differ from each other.
- Use initials or roles only. Nothing in this guide should identify a student, family or colleague.

The day at a glance

Time	Session	
8:30 - 9:45	1	The Lens
9:45 - 10:45	2	Understanding Autistic Experience: Sensory and Thinking
10:45 - 11:00		<i>Morning tea</i>
11:00 - 12:30	3	Autistic Experience at School
12:30 - 1:00		<i>Lunch</i>
1:00 - 2:15	4	Learning Design
2:15 - 3:15	5	Working in Partnership
3:15 - 4:00	6	Flourishing & Full Circle

The thread through the day

A few pages carry forward from session to session. Look for these:

Session 1	Think about your students and My starting point
Session 3	School-day map, school-level audit and Carry into design card
Session 4	Our school change, My students check and Commit
Session 5	Bridge to the next family conversation
Session 6	Start · Continue · Reconsider and Plan the next conversation

Key ideas

Neurodiversity and neurodivergence

Neurodiversity is the whole picture. Neurotypical and neurodivergent describe brain patterns within neurodiversity. Autism is one expression of that diversity.

A neurodiversity-affirming approach

- Acknowledging different ways of knowing, doing, being and belonging
- All people have strengths and experience challenges
- Differences are not deficits
- There is no right or wrong way to think, learn or behave
- Everyone experiences and interacts with the world differently

The social model

Use an environment-first lens: look for barriers in places, tasks, routines and expectations; ask what can change around the student; include the student's communication and experience; review whether the change makes participation more workable.

Autism as difference · Dynamic disability

A student's access and support needs may change with the task, environment, relationships and available capacity.

ACTIVITY**Think about your students** On your own

Bring two or three students to mind, ideally students who are quite different from each other. You will return to them all day.

Student	Strengths, interests or moments of connection that should stay visible
Student A	
Student B	
Student C	

Use initials or roles only. No names or identifying details.

What are you here for?	What would you like to understand better?

ACTIVITY**What did you notice?** After the student voice video

What stayed with you?	What would you like to understand more deeply?

ACTIVITY**Look again at school** Small groups

School routines reflect ideas about participation and learning. Consider:

- **What is school for?**
- **Who is school for?**
- **How do students learn?**
- **Whose ways of communicating, moving and participating are treated as expected?**

Choose one familiar routine or decision

Which assumptions shape it?

Who can access it easily?

Where might the environment create a barrier?

How could curiosity change the next response?

Discuss systems and routines, not identifiable students or colleagues.

ACTIVITY**My starting point** You will return to this in Session 6

What is school for?

In your own words, this morning

What am I curious about today?

Questions you hope the day will help with

Understanding Autistic Experience

Sensory and Thinking

Key ideas

Sensory processing

Sensory processing is the way the brain receives, processes and responds to information from the senses. There are eight senses, not five: touch, vision, taste, hearing and smell, plus proprioception (body in space), vestibular (balance and movement) and interoception (internal body signals). How the brain responds is not a choice.

Winnie Dunn's framework describes four patterns of sensory response: registration, seeking, sensitive and avoiding. A student can show different patterns in different senses, and patterns shift with load and context.

Sensory joy and stimming

Sensory experience can include pleasure, connection and regulation as well as discomfort or overload. Notice sensory joy, recognise stimming as authentic expression, and avoid treating difference as disruption by default.

Autistic thinking

- Detail-first (bottom-up) processing: noticing details before building the whole picture, with real strengths in pattern recognition and precision.
- Deep focus (monotropism): attention channelled fully into fewer things, supporting learning and flow; shifting attention takes time and warning.
- Executive functioning: planning, organisation, time management, working memory, meta-cognition, emotional regulation, flexibility, attention, task initiation and persistence.

Internal signals

Interoception is noticing and interpreting body signals. Alexithymia is difficulty identifying and describing emotions. Internal experience may not be visible, so reading early signs together helps everyone respond more consistently.

Choose one familiar classroom routine. What sensory demands does the environment or task create, and what options could increase access or choice?

Routine:

Sensory demand (environment or task)	Option that could increase access or choice	Question to explore
1		
2		
3		
4		

ACTIVITY**Strengths I can see** On your own

Detail-first thinking produces genuine strengths. What strengths do you see in the students you have in mind, and where do they show up?

Student	Strengths I have seen	Where or when I see them
Student A		
Student B		
Student C		

Be specific: what does each strength look like in your classroom?

ACTIVITY**Thinking discussion** Pairs

What deep interests do the students you have in mind have?

What do you notice when they are fully engaged, and does it look the same for each of them?

When during the school day do they have trouble getting started or shifting their attention?

Have you seen any of them fully absorbed in something at school? What were they doing?

What signs might you notice at school before one of these students becomes overwhelmed?

Student	Signs I might notice at school before overwhelm
Student A	
Student B	
Student C	

What would be useful for other staff and families to know about these signs?	Are the signs the same for each student?

Autistic Experience at School

Communication, Connection and Identity

Key ideas

Communication is multimodal

Speech is one part of communication. How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand. AAC (augmentative and alternative communication) is part of communication access and needs to be available where communication happens.

Supporting communication

Clear communication (familiar words, one idea or step at a time), processing time, and visual supports (showing information as well as saying it). The right support depends on the person and the moment.

Double empathy and connection

Misunderstanding can happen in both directions between people with different experiences and communication styles. Connection does not need to look one way, and can happen with family, at school, in the community and online.

Managing daily capacity

Think of a student's energy as a battery, or a set of spoons. Every day starts with a different charge; every action uses some; the right supports can recharge it. Capacity fluctuates from day to day.

Masking, identity and belonging

What is visible does not tell the whole story. A student may be working hard to appear "fine". A child who knows who they are, and feels genuinely valued for it, has more available for everything else.

Your Autistic staff

Everything today about students also applies to staff. Some of your staff are Autistic, whether or not they have told anyone. They bring real strengths, and the same thinking about load, predictability and clear communication supports them too. Build a culture where it is safe to be open, and never ask anyone to disclose.

ACTIVITY
Who is part of the communication network? On your own

Put one of the students you have in mind in the centre. Add one person or place now; you can return to the rest later.

Home family, carers, pets	Friends in person or online	School teachers, classmates
Community sport, clubs, shops	Student	Supports therapists, tools
Which parts of this network do I know little about? These are questions to explore with the student and their family 		

ACTIVITY
What should travel between people and places? Post-it notes

A communication strength Purple note	What helps communication Blue note	What I would like others to know Orange note

Think about relief teachers, specialist lessons, the playground and home. What should travel so the student does not have to start again with every new person?

ACTIVITY**Connection discussion** Pairs

When do the students you have in mind seem most comfortable connecting with others at school?

What kinds of connection does each of them enjoy? (Talking, gaming, sport, making things, shared interests, being together quietly, online interaction?)

Are there times in the school day when being social seems enjoyable, and times when it seems tiring or overwhelming?

What can educators change to make social connection feel safer, easier or more meaningful?

ACTIVITY**Masking discussion** Pairs

When might one of the students you have in mind be working hard to appear "fine" at school when they are not?

When and where at school do they seem most comfortable being themselves?

What could we change to help them feel more comfortable and supported?

Follow a typical school day as your students experience it, including whole-school routines: bells, assemblies, breaks, relief days and changes. Then mark how the same moments affect each of the students you have in mind.

Mark: **R** routine or transition **C** change **T** communication opportunity **P** moment to choose, pause or recover

Moment	What happens	Student A	Student B	Student C
Arrival				
Recess				
Lunch				
Departure				

The map is a working picture to extend, not a judgement of the student or school.

Costs

What adds demand or uncertainty?

Lightens

What reduces demand? What restores capacity or brings joy?

Where is a student's experience unknown?

Choose one to audit: enrolment and starting at the school · assemblies · relief-day arrangements · how change is communicated · where students can go to regulate.

Choose one school-level routine or process. What may its impact be, and why?

1 Name the routine or process.

2 Write what educators can observe without interpretation.

3 List possible environmental or task contributors.

4 Record what lightens demand and one question to investigate.

Choose from your school-day map and school-level audit.

Keep

One school practice to keep because it supports access, connection or joy

Reduce

Bring this to Session 4

One barrier or unnecessary demand to reduce

It is a: ☐ culture and learning ☐ routines ☐ teams and resourcing

Explore

One question to explore with students, families or staff

Learning Design

Designing an autism friendly school

Key ideas

Students come first

Move from understanding to design without turning students into a list of problems. Start with the real students you have in mind, a specific access question and evidence from your school-day map and audit.

Culture, resourcing and change

What staff say about students follows what leaders model. Where money and staff time go shows what a school values. Change that lasts usually starts small and visible: one system done well, explained, supported and reviewed.

Design one school change

In trios, you design one change to a school system, planned for this term, this year and the strategic plan. You then check it against the students you have in mind.

Systems to draw on

- Professional learning and coaching: staff learning that continues through the year.
- Predictability as policy: relief-day plans, change warnings and a stable timetable.
- Inclusion team and review cycles: adjustments planned and reviewed on a schedule.
- Documentation that helps staff: short templates, profiles that travel and a resource bank.

Universal first, then the continuum

Universal Design for Learning offers more than one way to access, engage and respond. Where a design still doesn't work for someone, support continues along a continuum: inclusive environment, universal supports, targeted supports, then individual adjustments, recorded through NCCD processes.

ACTIVITY**Our brief** Trios · agree on one school system you all recognise

Our system:

It is a: ☐ culture and learning ☐ routines ☐ teams and resourcing

At the moment, this system asks students to...

For some students and staff, that means...

We could change...

☐ Specific, workable, and free from blame or deficit labels

ACTIVITY**Options we chose** Trios

- ☐ Professional learning and coaching
- ☐ Predictability as policy
- ☐ Inclusion team and review cycles
- ☐ Documentation that helps staff
- ☐ Something else

Why it fits: which demand in our school does it answer?

ACTIVITY**Universal first** Trios · run these over your draft

- ☐ Can students find and understand what they need?
- ☐ Can they take part in more than one way?
- ☐ Can they pause, ask for help or recover?
- ☐ Is the support available when demand increases?
- ☐ Is there more than one way to access, engage and respond?

What we adjusted:

ACTIVITY**Quick review of your documentation** If your change involves it

- ☐ Can staff find it when they need it?
- ☐ Is it short enough to use?
- ☐ Does it reflect what is happening now?
- ☐ Does it reach relief teachers?

1 This term: a decision that costs little

2 This year: what we will build

3 The strategic plan: what makes it last

4 What we will observe

5 When we will review it

☐ Checked by another trio: still student-centred and environment-first

ACTIVITY
My students check On your own · private

Hold your trio's design up against each of the students you have in mind.

	Helps	No difference	Needs something more
Student A			
Student B			
Student C			

Where the design still doesn't work for someone, that is where targeted or individual support begins.

ACTIVITY
Commit After the gallery walk

What I will start this term	What I will notice	Who on my executive I will share it with

Working in Partnership

Partnership as strategy

Key ideas

Where partnerships converge

Students, families, school staff and paraprofessionals each bring different knowledge and a different relationship with the student. The student is at the centre of every partnership, and the skills that make partnership work are shared across all of them.

Effective collaboration

Shared goals · shared values · mutual trust and respect · consulting on decision-making · seeing other perspectives · inviting curiosity · centring student voice · assuming good intent.

Family engagement by design

The quality of a family's partnership should not depend on which teacher they get. Design the basics: a positive first contact each term, meeting protocols shaped with families, communication that keeps going when staff change, and access such as interpreters and flexible meeting times. Ask families whether they feel heard.

Repairing trust

When a relationship with a family has broken down, leaders can often help reset it: acknowledge what went wrong, listen first, and agree a fresh start with a clear next step.

Power dynamics

Power can sit in socio-economic status, historical and cultural experiences of education, language, understanding of school systems, and the perceived importance of school. It is also present in meeting structures, language and decision pathways.

Consultation literacy

Useful consultation has a clear shared purpose, open questions, more than one way to contribute, respect for student and family knowledge, accurate recording and an agreed action with follow-up. Ask, listen, and follow up.

When student capacity runs out

Meltdown, shutdown and School Can't are discussed without blame. Home and school may observe different parts of the student's experience. Focus on safety, what preceded the situation, what supports recovery and what can change.

ACTIVITY**Power dynamics** Post-it notes · 6 minutes

An imbalance from a home perspective	An imbalance from a school perspective	How I could address these imbalances

ACTIVITY**Student voice** After the video

What decisions were made, and who made them?	What impact did those decisions have on Adon?	How are the students I have in mind asked and heard?

ACTIVITY**Partnership activity** Table groups · 8 minutes

For each partner: what do they bring, and what challenges might they face?

Partner	Brings	Challenges
Student		
Parents and carers		
Teachers		
Paraprofessionals		

What do all four have in common?

ACTIVITY**What works?** Small groups · 6 minutes

Think of a family you have a good relationship with.

How did you establish this?	What does it look like?	Why does it work?

ACTIVITY**Consultation checklist** For your next meeting

- ☐ A clear, shared purpose
- ☐ Open questions
- ☐ More than one way to contribute
- ☐ Respect for student and family knowledge
- ☐ Accurate recording of what was heard
- ☐ An agreed action, responsibility and follow-up

ACTIVITY**Bridge to the next family conversation** On your own · bring this to Session 6

Prepare for one purposeful conversation.

What needs to be understood?

What question will open the conversation?

How will the student's voice be included?

What can be decided together?

How and when will the school follow up?

Flourishing & Full Circle

One school change, one purposeful conversation

Key ideas

Belonging, capacity and joy

- Belonging: being recognised, included and able to participate as oneself.
- Capacity: what the day costs, protects and restores.
- Joy: interests, connection and authentic expression.

Return to these when judging whether a change supports flourishing.

Bringing the day together

A neurodiversity-affirming lens that begins with the person; a more accessible school shaped by student experience; and positive partnership that brings student, family and school knowledge together.

ACTIVITY

Bringing it all together

Table groups · 8 minutes

The strongest thing I'm taking back to my school	Our table's three ideas most worth spreading	Who needs to hear each one, and in which meeting or moment?

Start

One strategy to start, something small you can start next week

Continue

One practice to continue, something today confirmed you already do well

Reconsider

One approach to reconsider, something you would now do differently

How will I know it worked?	What evidence will show it?

This card is yours. Share one thing on it with your executive team. Your Session 4 "this term" step can be your Start.

Choose the real conversation you'll have within two weeks, with a student's family or with the student themselves.

What I'll share A strength first	What I'll ask Specifically	What I'll offer

My opening sentence, word for word

When	Where	How

Turn back to "My starting point" in Session 1. Read your own words. What's different now?

Where was I this morning?	Where am I now?

What will I do differently in my leadership?

Answer it in one sentence, for yourself.

Connections that continue

Today is a starting point. These supports continue after the workshop.

Webinars and deep dives	Follow-ups on UDL, executive functioning, sensory design, anxiety and more. [Titles, dates and links to confirm]
Online Community of Practice	A place to keep talking with other educators after today. [Link or QR code to add]
Positive Partnerships	positivepartnerships.com.au
Visual Supports Checklist	A practical resource for reviewing an existing support or planning a new one. [Where to find it, to confirm]
NCCD	NCCD Meetings Tool Kit and current official NCCD information: nccd.edu.au
Disability Standards for Education	Getting started; Advocating with and for your child; Milestones and transitions (Department of Education)
Autism Connect	National autism helpline: 1300 308 699
Disability Gateway	1800 643 787
Carer Gateway	Emotional, practical and financial support for carers: 1800 422 737

My notes
